MIGRATION AND CHRISTIAN MISSION AMONG MIGRANTS

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Introduction:

India is entering a qualitatively new phase of socio, economic and cultural changes and these are particularly evident in urban India. It is generally agreed that urban people perceive and receive changes more openly than their rural counterparts. Often urbanization and change are interdependent and inter-related. The acceptance level of change among the migrants tends to be much higher and comparatively faster. The issue of urbanization and change needs our careful scrutiny so as to gain insights for possible Christian mission among migrants. Attempts are made in this paper to look at the reality of urbanization as an agent of change and examine its impact on select aspects of migrants so as to raise pertinent questions for doing Christian mission among them in contemporary urban India.

The technological advances in post-Second World War era have had an immense impact on the world's population. Today, it is no longer necessary for the bulk of the population to be engaged in agriculture alone as the world is now able to sustain a large number of people in cities. Consequently, the world is rapidly becoming urbanized. At the beginning of the twentieth century, a little over ten percent of the world population lived in cities. However, at the beginning of the twenty-first century, more than half of the world is living in cities. John Palen points out that this urban growth is primarily taking place in Asia, Africa and South America.[1] This means that the reality of urbanization will affect the non-Western world significantly, since much of the Western Hemisphere is already urbanized. Therefore, the implications of urbanization for the non-Western world are tremendous. Although urbanization is not new, what's new is the degree and the speed with which non-Western countries are becoming urban. While in some ways India follows global patterns, the process of urbanization in India is unique, as it has its own historical and cultural contexts in which urbanization is being shaped.

Defining Urbanization:

[1]John Palen The Urban-World. New York: McGraw-Hill Book Company, 1987states that 13 percent of the world was urban in 1900. By 1950, that figure had risen to 28 percent and in 1975, it was 41 and by the year 2003 it reached 52 percent.

It is not easy to define urbanization, as no one definition is acceptable to all. As is true at the global level, no one definition of urbanization is accepted in India. In fact, the study of urbanization in India has been described as 'a balloon into which each social scientist blows his [or her] own meaning.'[2]There are numerous ways by which one can define it since it is a complex subject that can be approached from different angles. Here, we will focus on a couple of definitions. According to Prakasa Rao, urbanization in India involves: "(a) Concentration of people at population densities higher than those associated with agricultural populations, with only very rare exceptions on either side; (b) population shift (migration) from rural to urban areas; (c) occupational shift from agricultural to non-agricultural.[3]" While this definition is quite comprehensive, it probably does not take into account the modern process of urbanization wherein a new technological as well as urban to urban migration is becoming a reality. R. P. Misra looks at urbanization as the process that "reveals itself through temporal, spatial, and sectoral changes in demographic, social, economic, technical and environmental aspects of life in a given society.[4]" Misra builds his definition of urbanization on the issue of comprehensive changes, and that is worth taking into consideration as we look at urbanization and change in this paper.

Urbanization and Migration Dynamics:

According to the Ministry of Urban Development, India is in the midst of a gigantic urban increase, claiming to have fifty three cities with a million plus population[5] Just a decade ago this figure was less than half of its current number, which shows the rapidity with which Indian cities are growing. A significant percentage of this increase is due to migration. Migration is generally understood as the movement of people from one place to another.[6] However, sociologists look at migration as a form of geographical or spatial mobility between one geographic unit and another.[7] It implies a permanent or semi-permanent change in the place of residence. Commenting on this, Kanjamala makes helpful observations: "Legally speaking, migration involves crossing over administrative units or boundaries. When the national boundary of the country is involved it is called international migration and if the

[2]Vasant Kuman Bawa, Indian Metropolis: Urbanization, Planning and Management. New Delhi: Inter-India Publication, 1987, 30.
[3]Prakas V.L.S. Rao, Urbanization in India: Spatial Dimensions. New Delhi: Concept Publishing Company, 1983, 13.
[4]R. P. Misra ed. Million Cities of India, New Delhi: Vikas Publishing House, 1978, 23
[5]www.moud.gov.in/urbanmorphology/accessed on October 20, 2013.
[6] See the following for some studies on migration in the Indian context: Jan Breman, *Of Peasants, Migrants and Paupers,* Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1985., A. P. Katti, *Seasonal In-migrants in Rural Shimuga,* Dharwar: Demographic Research Center, 1966., Swaranjit Mehta, *Migration: A Spatial Perspective,* Jaipur: Rawat Publication, 1990., BRK Raju, *Developmental Migration,* New Delhi: Concept Publishing Co, 1989., J. P. Singh, *Patterns of Rural -Urban Migration in India,* New Delhi: Amar Prakashan, 1989.etc.
[7] Hassan, M., Population Geography. Jaipur: Rawat Publication, 2005, 281.

migration takes place within the national boundary, it is termed internal migration." [8] A huge internal migration is taking place in India especially in the past three decades. The Census of India generally divides internal migration into Intra-State migration and Inter-State migration. These two are further classed into, rural to rural and urban to urban migration.[9] These classifications help us to understand comprehensive aspects of migration. Before we move on, we should also take into consideration one more point pertaining to migration. Migration has a double effect. Many see it as an employment opportunity and feel happy about it, whereas there are many who see it as a systematic exploitation of human beings. [10] While it is true that migration can be perceived negatively, but for some it is an absolute necessity and a reality that cannot be bypassed.

The post-colonial phase of urbanization can be traced back to the Nehruvian policy of industrialization. In the Indian government's first five-year plan, against the wishes of MK Gandhi, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru encouraged industrialization in India. Thus, with the emergence of industry in certain regions of India, urbanization spread rapidly. The most industrialized regions became the most urbanized regions.[11] This explains why states like Maharashtra, Gujarat and Tamil Nadu, being leading industrial states; have a high percentage of urban population. The impact of industrialisation in India had to wait for a couple of decades. It was only in the early seventies that rapid urbanisation began to grip India. Millions of rural people were drawn to the industrial cities. Heavy migration of the rural population to the industrial centers of India has accelerated during the last three decades.
Indian people have been thought of as almost stagnant and immobile in the world. Since India has been essentially an agricultural country, farmers have played a great role in its history. Vijaya Punekar, commenting on the immobility of a traditional farmer, says 'Lack of knowledge of the world beyond his limited horizon, absence of initiative, caste restrictions on choice of occupations and transportation, all are some factors responsible for the immobility of an Indian villager' [12]The strong influence of the caste system, which imposed heavy restrictions on every aspect of the people's lives made it extremely difficult for people to move out of their villages. In addition, it has been widely believed that the rural

[8] Augustine Kanjamala, "Social Analysis of Migration in India" L. Stanislaus and Jose Joseph eds., Migration and Mission in India, Delhi: Ishvani Kendra and ISPCK, 1.
[9] Kanjamala…1.
[10] Ignatius Soreng, Nicholas Barla and G. Christopher. "Tribal Migration and Mission: Special Reference to the Domestic Workers of East India in the Big Cities." In Migration and Mission in India, edited by L. Sanislaus and Jose Joseph. Delhi: Ishvani Kendrea and ISPCK, 2007, 56.
[11] Prakas V.L. S. Rao, *Urbanisation in India: Spatial Dimensions.* New Delhi: Concept Publishing Company, 1983, 53.
[12]Vijaya Punekar, *A Study of North Indians in Bangalore*Bombay: Popular Prakashan, 1974, 58.

population in India is relatively non-migratory 'because it is too strongly tied to its village origins by bonds of kinship, marriage customs, language, and centuries of in-group living to be easily diverted to the comparative insecurity and strangeness of the city.'[13]Furthermore, what Kanjamala observed is true when he says, that the Indian population was considered highly immobile due to its low level of education, traditional values and poor adaptive ability to deal with problems linked to migration, poor transport and communication facilities which adds to low movement of people.[14]

However, a close look at the history of India provides us a glimpse of the constant migration of people. At least, a segment of the Indian population has been migrating since ancient times in and out of India. For centuries now, thousands of Indians have migrated to nearby countries in search of a better a life. No wonder, we find heavy concentrations of Indians in Fiji, the Mauritius Islands, West Indies, Malaysia, Singapore, Sri Lanka, East and South Africa, and several other countries around the world. These migrations are centuries old. Our concern here is primarily migration within the country. Although movements of some segments of Indian population have been always observed, it has picked a strong momentum in the post-independence era and especially after the 1970s onwards. Hence, what Bogue and Zachariah asserted is correct 'A discussion of urbanization in India (and, in fact, almost everywhere in the world) fundamentally is a discussion of net rural-to-urban migration.'[15]The fact that India's urban population has grown considerably during the past three to four decades indicates a significant movement of people from rural to urban centers. Hence, the whole migration phenomenon deserves careful scrutiny and analysis.

Understanding Causes of Migration:

As we look at contemporary trends of migration, we notice various kinds of movements of people. Some are voluntarily moving, and others move because they have no choice other than to move. Some are seasonal migrants; others are permanent migrants. Some migrate as single, male individuals, whereas others move along with their entire extended family and clan. Migration also takes place for religious reasons. Some people settle down in a pilgrim center in the later part of their lives, whereas other nomadic people who are migrants by tradition, have geared their economy to their nomadic way of life.

[13]Bogue Donald J and K.C. Zachariah, 'Urbanization and Migration in India,' Roy Turner ed., *India's Urban Future* Berkeley: University of California Press,1962, 29.

[14]Kanjamala, "Social Analysis of Migration in India" L. Stanislaus and Jose Joseph eds., Migration and Mission in India, Delhi: Ishvani Kendra and ISPCK, 2007, 5.

[15] Bouge and Zachariah,27.

Then, of course, there are those who are involved in trade and business which requires an itinerant way of life. Although migration is spoken of as a movement of people from rural to urban areas, it can be from town to city and from city to city too. Today, cities of India are flooded with migrants of every kind, though the huge percentage of them may be from rural areas. Bawa, in referring to Weiner's work, 'assumes that at least a third of the population increase in the urban area must be the result of migration.'[16] Whereas, the contemporary trends of migration take this percentage much higher.

Although social scientists have come up with various theories to explain the causes of the migration, we will confine ourselves for this paper to the Push and Pull Theory of Everett Lee in which he conceptualized the factors associated with the decision to migrate and the process of migration into the following categories: (1) Factors associated with the area of origin; (2) Factors associated with the area of destination; (3) Intervening obstacles; and (4) Personal factors. Lee speaks about 'pushes from the areas of origin and 'pulls' to areas of destination.[17] Although Lee's observations are based on the contemporary European urban context, much of that still holds ground however, more factors are added to this theory as the process of urbanization has now been taking place in the globalized context. Some significant features like urban to urban, town to urban, and national to international migration need further scrutiny. For the purpose of this section, we will use the framework of Lee as we analyze the push and pull factors in the contemporary urban India.

Migration Caused by 'Push and Pull' Factors:

One of the major reasons why people migrate to cities is economical, where they earn their livelihood. This is largely linked with the increasing Indian population that is now literate and educated. Even if they are marginally educated, they tend to move to cities to either find jobs that fit their education or enhance their potential for a better lifestyle. The majority of Indians depend on agriculture for their livelihood but, due to a constant increase in the population and the limited availability of cultivable land, some are forced to search for other means of employment. Furthermore, most of the cultivable land in India is dependent on rain; consequently, when there is a shortage of rain, thousands are displaced and forced to leave their villages in search of jobs. It is important to note in this context that a sizable segment of those who migrate to the cities are basically low caste, landless laborers. Since most of them

[16]Bawa Vasant Kumar, *Indian Metropolis: Urbanization, Planning and Management* New Delhi: Inter-India Publication, 1987, 50.

[17] Kanjamala, 3.

do not have any land to cling on to, they move on to the city. Bulsara is right when he states, 'adverse and unsatisfactory economic conditions in the original habitat form the largest single push factor to drive or stimulate the movement of the people to the city.'[18]Due to a continuous increase in population growth, great pressure is put upon natural resources. As a result, many are forced to leave their villages in search of new employment. It is often observed that people perceive the city as a beacon of hope for employment of every kind.

Kanjamala asserts, "For the male migrant, the most important reason for migration was employment opportunity." [19]Since cities provide several options for better employment, many educated and skilled people also move to the city. These are not necessarily rural people, rather they are from towns or cities that tend to migrate to the bigger cities, because bigger cities normally provide better employment opportunities and better wages. Since cities are strong centers of commerce and industry, there is a constant inflow and outflow of services personnel. All kinds of people are transferred to and from cities. These include government employees and officers, factory-skilled and clerical workers. Additionally, small businessmen also expand their business beyond small towns to bigger cities. 'The largest number of migrants belongs to the subordinate technical occupations, the second largest group being engaged in sales and related occupations.'[20]These transferees may or may not permanently settle in the city, but they definitely contribute to its size and shape. This is particularly true of the urban-to-urban migration of service personnel. However, there are also those who are self-employed and want to explore new grounds for better gain. These include merchants, small shop owners and small industry people. They tend to move toward cities.

In recent decades, a significant growth of industrial centers in certain cities has been attracting many people from all over the country. This has been changing the urban face of India. The relationship between modern urbanization and industrialization is becoming more and more evident. The 'Industrial Revolution' in India affected the production of traditional crafts and occupations which had been previously determined by the caste system. The effects of industrialization on the villages were evident.

[18]Bulsara, J.F. Problems of Rapid Urbanization in India. Bombay: Popular Prakashan, 1964, 37.
[19] Kanjamala…16.
[20]Kopardekar, H. D. Social Aspect of Urban Development. A case Study of the Patterns of Urban Development in the Developing Countries. Bombay: Popular Prakashan, 1986, 141.

Industrial centers were mostly in large urban centers, which affected the once thriving centers of the traditional small scale and cottage industries in various parts of India. As a result, many craftsmen and artisans in rural India became jobless, and many of them were forced to take refuge in the cities.

Certain regions of India have become industrial magnets that have been pulling people out of their small villages and towns. Though the industrial growth in India has not been phenomenal, it has been one of the main reasons why people tend to move to a new city-ward, where some kind of employment is normally available. Prakasa Rao contends that the most industrialized regions are the most urbanized regions. He gives examples of such regions: Calcutta-Hooghly-Damodar Valley; Bombay-Pune; Kanpur-Lucknow; Madras-Chinglepet and Delhi-Meerut-Agra.[21] The state of Maharashtra is the most industrialized state in India; consequently, it is also the most urbanized state. This is why a huge industrial population is found in its urban centers like Mumbai, Pune and Nagpur.

Bogue and Zachariah interestingly observe "in India the propensity to migrate to urban areas is much higher among literate and educated people than among the illiterate."[22] This statement can be challenged, since in the recent past more and more educated and professionally qualified people are also migrating to the urban centers of India. The literacy rate in India has been very low, but in recent decades it has been on the rise. As the level of education raises, the tendency to travel greater distances increases, people are inclined to move into new areas and learn new languages and they develop a spirit of adaptation. Because of the Indian government's initiative in providing at least a primary level of education to all, and its considerable effort to introduce adult literacy, the level of literacy has been significantly elevated. Those who are able to read and write, find it easy to leave the villages and explore new grounds in search of better employment opportunities. Raj Bala makes an interesting observation in this regard: 'One of the forces underlying the growing popularity of education among farming families was their desire to divert some of their members to non-agricultural vocations.'[23] This is indicative of the attitude of rural families toward their educated children. It is easier for educated youth to get employment and earn money in the city than to live in the village and be involved in agriculture.

[21] Rao,53.
[22] Bogue and Zachariah,53.
[23]Raj Bala, Trends in Urbanization in India: 1901-1981. Jaipur: Rawat Publications, 1986, 113.

Realizing the importance of higher and professional education, many marginally educated rural people either send their children to cities or move to cities for the sake of education for their children. It is a fact that urban centers provide better educational facilities. Practically all major cities of India are known for their universities and educational facilities. These educational centers act as magnets for students, who having studied in cities, rarely go back. One thing should be remembered: in most cases, generally the high castes who have resources are in a better position to afford to send their children to cities for educational purposes. What Kopardekar has observed, a migration pattern in relation to the high caste is noteworthy. According to him, the high castes 'were the first to sense the advantages of Western education, and the sons of those who left the villages were educated and became the first teachers, officials, lawyers, doctors and judges.'[24]

Natural calamities also force people to migrate to cities. Famines, floods and cyclones are frequent occurrences in India. The vicious cycle of de-forestation and famine has been affecting parts of India considerably. The forests have been destroyed for various reasons, affecting the ecology of the country. Every year droughts and famines are becoming a regular phenomenon in India consequently; waves of people are forced to leave such drought prone areas. Most of them take shelter in the cities. In this way, sections of villages move out in groups and settle either on the fringes of cities or in the deep slums. Frequent flooding is another reason for people to move from flood-affected areas to the safety of the cities. India enjoys long coastal borders but often these areas are struck by storms and cyclones, and people are dispersed in search of safe places. Then there are riverside villages that get affected annually by the flooding of the rivers. A section of these people also tends to move out and migrate to cities.

Many governmental policies and laws are also affecting people and livelihoods, causing a movement of people. Kopardekar lists different government acts and laws that have affected the rural and small town people in particular: 'Legislation like the Tenancy Act, ceiling on ownership of farming land, Minimum Wages Act, prevention of bonded labor, liquidation of rural indebtedness, protection of depressed classes from the clutches of the big landholders and money lenders …'[25] Most of these legislative acts were introduced after independence which directly or indirectly affected people; many of whom had no choice but to move into the cities.

[24] Kopardekar…70.
[25] Kopardekar,147.

Further, the initiatives to introduce the Green and White Revolutions have brought much mechanization to the farming and dairy industries. As a result, many have had to leave their traditional jobs related to dairy and farming. Impoverishment caused by the Green Revolution is such that many small land holding farmers are forced to become daily wage earners and fill urban slums. This is to say that such government initiatives though were started with good intentions, affected some adversely, causing them to be displaced.

The same thing can be said about the government's effort to eradicate the ill effects of the caste system also has contributed to the movement of people. While addressing the evil side of the caste system, the measures that were initiated by some of the government policies affected certain groups of people in an adverse way. According to Raj Bala, 'unemployment among the service caste in rural areas was growing with the gradual break of *jajmani* (caste) system.'[26]Many of those who were involved in carrying out their traditional occupations, especially in the villages, were forced to explore new employment due to the laws enacted by the government. As per the government laws are concerned, practicing of the traditional caste system, especially of its caste discrimination and ill treatment of the outcastes is discouraged, and new reforms have been introduced which have apparently relaxed the grip of caste on the masses. Consequently, many low castes, losing their traditional caste-oriented occupations, could not be employed with the given caste related occupations. This made them difficult to survive in villages, consequently some of them had to move out of rural areas to explore new avenues of employment. That is probably the reason why most slums in the cities have been filled with such village artisans.

India has seen major political upheaval right from the eve of its independence. The partition of India and Pakistan in 1947 drove millions of people off their original homeland. 'Partition of the Indian Sub-continent into India and Pakistan has been one of the important stimuli for the movement of population since 1947 … and 7 million Hindus came to India from across the borders.' [27] Most finally landed in the major cities and towns of India; prominent among them were Punjabi Hindus, Sikhs, and Sindhis. The shape of some north Indian cities has been drastically changed due to the influx of these refugees. Even the division of India into different states also resulted in the migration of vast numbers of people. Certain refugee colonies eventually merged with cities and have contributed to the process of

[26] Raj Bala, …
[27] Bogue & Zachariah,43

urbanization. Even after partition, northern and northwestern border tensions caused two wars with Pakistan, which also drove many border people toward the cities.

In addition, continuous tensions with China, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka keep adding Tibetans, Gorkhas, Bangladeshis and Sri Lankan Tamils, along with Sikhs and Kashmiri Hindus to different cities of India. It is estimated that about 9 million people have migrated to India from Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and other countries in the post-independence era. In addition, with religious fundamentalism on the rise in recent decades, communal and religious riots are becoming more and more common in India. These riots bring pressure on certain segments of the affected population, forcing them to move out of those areas. Thus, many communities are uprooted as safer living space is sought in the shelter of the cities.

It is observed that male migration is dominant in Indian cities. Over a period of time, these male migrants tend to bring their wives and children to the cities. This is described as dependent migration. Single males who migrate usually marry village women and bring them to the cities. As the city expands, it absorbs several villages into its fold. Village dwellers suddenly become part of the city. Strictly speaking, this absorption may not be called migration, but it definitely changes the status of these rural people.

Mass media has been said to be influential in helping spread the pattern of urbanization. Though mass media such as radio and television are controlled by the government of India, they are managed mostly by urban people. Most of what has been produced reflects urban lifestyle and patterns. Because of advanced technologies, the effects of these media have been seen even in the remotest parts of India. Cinemas, newspapers, and an increasing rate of literacy have also been influencing the masses toward urbanization. Cinema has been a powerful medium for communicating a predominantly urban lifestyle. Most radio and television programs are essentially city oriented. 'The question is not whether this is good or bad, but that they raise more curiosity about life in big cities in most minds of the rural populace.'[28] The introduction of many luxurious items on television commercials definitely helps create an urban mind-set. Given opportunity, many young people are pulled toward the cities. It is only after coming, that they face the realities of city life, but then it is too late for them to return to the villages.

[28] Kopardekar,135.

They struggle to adjust with the hard life in the city yet continue to influence another village folk to join them.

Impact of Change on Migrants:

Before we discuss the process of change in urban India, it is essential that we define what change is. For our purpose, Gordon Lippitt's definition of change is most acceptable and least complex. He defines change as a "planned or unplanned alteration in the status quo in an organism, situation, or process."[29]His categories of change include "transmitted social change", which occurs without any intentional direction, and "transformed social change", which occurs when persons or groups or structures change themselves or others by deliberate effort or resolutions.

Rapid urbanization in India is bringing about many changes, affecting practically every aspect of urban life. However, we cannot neglect the continuity in several other areas of urban life. Raj Gandhi's distinction in this regard is valid: 'Here we must make it clear that there is a difference in change in degree [the quantitative change] and change in kind [the qualitative change].[30] In certain areas of urban life, people tend to adapt to change at the behavioral level but not necessarily at the attitudinal. Such change remains at a superficial level. However, family and religious life, occupational patterns and certain aspects of the caste system have definitely been affected. The following section will deal with those aspects of urban life that have been affected by changes.

Family

The basic component of Indian society is the family. The traditional extended or joint family has been India's strength. However, Indian society is undergoing transformation as a result of industrialization and urbanization, as well as the policies adopted to reorganize rural life.[31] It is also experiencing transformation as a consequence of the efforts by the government to reshape family types and functions by different legislation. It is argued that the tempo of industrialization considerably influences the structure and functions of family. It transforms the family into a unit of consumption, the function of production being taken over by industries and occupations associated with them.

[29]Gordon Lippitt. Visualizing Change: Model Building and the Change Process.Fairfax Va: NTL Learning Resources Corporation,1973, 37.

[30]Raj Gandi S. "Kin, and Caste Interactions of the Women of an Urban Sub-Caste." Proceedings of the 30th International Congress of Human Science. Graciela de la Lama ed. Mexico City: Mexico1976, 3.

[31]A. R. Desai, A. R. Urban Family and Family Planning in India. Bombay: Popular Prakashan. 1980, 23.

One of the most visible impacts of urbanization is the trend from the traditional to the nuclear family. Though the traditional joint or extended family still persists in urban India, the trend toward the nuclear family is gaining strength. This phenomenon has implications for decision-making in the family. Traditionally, all of the decisions were made by the elderly male, with the understanding that other members of the family would obey. However, this is changing in the urban centers. A very vivid description of such change is given by AR Desai:

> The community life lived by majority of the urban population is woven within the matrix of the religious, communal, caste and other associational framework. The control of the elders to a large extent disappears and the nuclear family is left to make its own decisions. There is also a growing tendency for the younger family members to be treated as individuals rather than as family members. This is suggestive of the processes of change that are taking place in authority structure within the family, particularly among the educated upper-and middle-class families (1980:33-34).

Nevertheless, though the structure of urban families tends toward nuclearity, the attitudinal inclination still seems to be toward traditional family values. When discussing the urban family, it is essential to note kinship patterns in urban India. It is generally believed that kinship ties lose their hold in the urban centers. It is true that the complexity of urban life brings certain restrictions to kinship continuity in the cities. However, it has been observed by Sylvia Vatuk [32], IP Desai[33]and others that in order to meet the demands of complex modern urban life, a modified extended family is emerging. Here, kin and clan play a central role. Such a structure may not look very traditional or formal, but it consists of a series of nuclear families joined together on an equal basis for mutual aid and functioning. These individual nuclear families do not necessarily stay together under one roof to form a traditional joint family. Members of kin and clans may be scattered in the city, living as nuclear units, but for all practical purposes, they function as one large joint family. Once again, when we think in terms of change in the patterns of kinship in urban India, we observe a strange anomaly between continuity and change. The

[32]Sylvia Vatuk, Kinship and Urbanization. Berkeley: University of California, Press, 1972,
[33]I P Desai."An Analysis" Part of "Symposium: Caste and Joint Family." Sociological Bulletin 4 (2) 1955.

fact that certain aspects of family patterns are changing is perhaps indicative of openness to spiritual change.

Caste

The caste system, originally based on occupational class segregation, was the basis of living patterns in cities, towns and villages in ancient India. For many sociologists, caste is thought to be a rural phenomenon, closely connected with the peasant society and economy. Therefore, the presumption is that caste somehow is antithetical to non-agricultural economy. However, over the centuries, the caste system has been going through a transformation, especially in modern cities. Western thinkers like Karl Marx and Max Weber predicted that the caste system would not survive modern technological and sociological changes. They predicted almost a dismissal of it in the industrial cities of India. It is true the caste system is undergoing change. Some of its elements, however, are still keeping a strong hold on the people of India, even on urban people. The caste system in India has resisted change for a long time and has adapted by allowing certain aspects of it to undergo transformation. On the whole, the caste system structurally remains strong and continues to be an integral part of Indian society.

It would be interesting to find out what aspects of the caste system have been undergoing changes in urban India. Dube contends that 'caste barriers have fallen in many places or have been transformed into class antagonisms.[34]' Gandhi advocates that in its economic dimension, caste is slowly but surely changing into class.[35] Yet N M Srinivas[36] has observed that caste consciousness and organizations have increased in modern India. Thus, there are contradictory views expressed by different scholars on the caste system in India.

Srinivas cites examples of continuity of caste and occupation in cites. According to him, rural barbers, when they migrate to towns, work in hair-cutting salons, washer men start laundries, smiths work in furniture shops, oilmen sell if not press oil, *malis* work as gardeners, *chamars* work in shoe-shops, Brahmins are cooks, teachers and lawyers. All practice similar occupations and stay in the areas where

[34]C. S. Dube, ed. India Since Independence. Social Report on India 1947-1972. New Delhi: Vikas Publishing House, 1977, 71.
[35] Raj Gandhi, Kin and…3.
[36]Shrinivas, M. N. Social Change in Modern India. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1967.

their caste fellows are. The hierarchical attitudes of hereditary occupations are carried by the people from the villages to the towns and cities. Most modern educated high caste Hindus preserve some elements of traditional behavior in their interactions with other members. As observed by many, caste consciousness still lingers in respect to marriage, mainly because of the traditional caste practices in the family structure. While the hold of the caste system appears to be diminishing in urban India, it would be a mistake to say that city people have been completely freed from its influence. The change in the caste system is one of degree, not of kind.

With the introduction and growth of a modern market economy system in India, the traditional system of economic and social interdependence between the castes has been undermined. Under the traditional caste structure, a person was expected to carry out his/her own occupation, assigned by their caste. Even traditional cities in India carried out the same occupational patterns until the beginning of this century. But now a clear change has been observed in modern cities. Once the traditional hereditary nature of caste occupations has been significantly affected by the impact of industrialization, urbanization, and Western educational institutions, occupational mobility increases, affecting not only the caste system but also the socio-economic position of all classes.

Because of urbanization, the horizon of occupational mobility is wide open. A person from a lower rank, if eligible, may be hired at any level. This kind of occupational mobility is not permitted by the caste-dominated structure. Moreover, some recent government policies, by reserving certain quota or governmental jobs to the ‘scheduled castes’ (mostly the lower and the outcastes), and ‘scheduled tribes’ (mostly the animistic mountain non-caste people), have encouraged occupational mobility.

In recent years, caste has been very much used by the politicians, though officially at the government level, it is banned. Due to the increasing use of caste in politics, both caste and politics are being changed. Because of political benefits, there is a growing tendency to stick to one's own caste and manipulate it to gain more benefits from the government. This tendency is much more clearly seen among the lower caste people, who have been offered various concessions and benefits by certain government policies. This has led to more caste consciousness, particularly in the cities. Caste appears to have become a vehicle of political power and economic gain. Dube's remarks in this regard are noteworthy: “Political interests may unite or divide them into factions or persuade them to form

coalitions with other castes or to fight against them.[37]" This could be an indication of the growing influence of caste in the urban centers of India.

Because of the Indian government's policy of providing equal opportunities of learning to every citizen, every caste group has access to education. This has helped especially the low caste people to acquire the education and the skills for professional jobs. The monopoly of the high castes, particularly the Brahmins, over education has therefore been gradually diminishing. The widespread advance of modern education is particularly seen in the urban centers, where a large number of schools, colleges, and professional institutions have been educating the masses.

This has in turn encouraged the educated masses to move into occupations of their own choice. Today, in an urban setting, a person of low social ranking can hold a higher position than a high caste person. 'Occupation thus became a relatively independent element in social status' this is considered to be a significant move from the traditional caste-ridden occupations.

A sizable number of those who have become professionals are now considered middle class in urban centers. "The development of professions along with the salaried occupations led to the growth of the middle classes, and the newly educated middle classes in India cut across different castes."[38] On the basis of education, skill, profession, and economic status, a person of lower caste ranking can be elevated to the middle class status. This is an emerging phenomenon in urban India. It indicates a gradual move toward the change from a caste-oriented to a class-oriented society.

A person with good earnings can buy properties in a high caste dominated residential area without much problem, despite his or her lower caste background. "For many, it is quite difficult to accept so suddenly the new criterion of wealth against that of caste and birth with which they were accustomed."[39] Cities demand a materialistic outlook. The upper castes normally do not enjoy the same privileges of prosperity and respect in the cities that they once did. "Thus, frustrated in their efforts to

[37] Dube…71.
[38] Raj Gandhi, "Religion in India." In Urban India. Raj Gupta ed. Deli: Vikas Publication, 1983, 44.
[39] Paul Devanandan, and M M Thomas."Modern Hindu Attitude Toward Christian Evangelism." Union Seminary Quarterly Review 12(3): 1957,43

climb up the social ladder, they glorify the caste structure all the more.[40]" This is a dilemma many urbanites are experiencing.

Religion

Religion has been an integral part of Indian society. In fact, traditional Indian society has been well integrated into the framework of Hinduism. Traditional cities in India have been, for the most part, its religious centers. Thus, cities like Varanasi, Allahabad, and Amritsar are known religious centers even today, "and recently the reform movements such as the Prarthana Samaj, The Brahmo Samaj, etc., have found their beginnings in the cities."[41] Though people in cities still tend to be religious, religion does not carry the same weight in their lives as in the past. This is primarily because "Westernization, industrialization, urbanization and secularization have acted as the powerful forces of change."[42]The influence of science and technology and the spread of modern education have definitely affected the religion of Indian urbanites.

Despite the fact that urbanization is bringing a lot of pressure on the religious practices of people, "the importance and influence of religion is apparently increasing" argues Kopardekar [43] In the midst of busy urban life, people still tend to take the shelter of religion for peace and tranquility. In fact, some studies (e.g. Ghurye 1968) indicate that there is an increase in the awareness of religious identity among Indian urbanites. Gandhi observes that "Hinduism has shown extreme flexibility in adapting to urban conditions."[44] The same is said to be true of Islam and Sikhism and, to some extent, Christianity in India. Kopardekar's observation is crucial in this regard: "Growing patronage of temples of Hindus, mosques of Muslims or churches of Christians, or the contesting of elections and running of several educational and other institutional associations on the basis of religion and the large queues at religious places or festivals and other occasions are indications of growing influence of religion in the cities of India"[45]

In recent years, several religious militant movements have started in different cities of India. Communal and religious tensions are on the rise. "The revival of the old Sanskrit tradition and the change of the old

[40] Paul Devanandan and Thomas… 44
[41] Raj Gandhi…57.
[42] Raj Gandhi…57.
[43] Kopardekar…127-128.
[44] Raj Gandhi…57.
[45] Kopardekar,128.

traditions have continued simultaneously in Indian cities."[46]New meanings are being added to old rituals, and new forms, suitable to urban life, are adapted. This may indicate that urbanization is transforming traditional religion.

Why are the Indian cities becoming more and more religious? The modern Hindu revival, which has its roots in the urban centers, is a reaction against the attacks on Hinduism from non-Hindu sources. Thus, the revival is bringing reform and reinterpretation of religion in modern India.[47] Another reason given by Kopardekar[48] is the growing insecurity and frustration in the cities. In the insecure urban situation, people find security in their traditional religion, though it may be old and outdated in many ways. So urban people may be modernized outwardly, but within the domestic circle, they act like staunch religious believers. An interesting dual culture and outlook is being developed by the Indian urbanite. This could again be referred to as a double standard of living and confirms our argument that in the urban centers of India, continuity and change are evident.

Reflecting on Migrant Conditions:

It is normally believed that most migrants in the city face tremendous problems as they initially feel uprooted, disoriented, insecure and unsettled. This is particularly true with those who are pushed where they are forced into an environment that is strange, unfamiliar and to an extent, hostile. Generally, most migrants find it hard to adjust with the change in their environment, living conditions, interpersonal relationships and language as well as occupation related issues. The urban job market requires education and specialized skills that most rural migrants do not possess. This brings tremendous pressure on them to adjust with new job environments. Since the rural skills and experiences with which these migrants come to the cities are of limited value, they generally become unskilled workers.

Often the desire for migrants to move socially and economically upward is thwarted by the demands of their mere survival. The struggle to survive in the city normally takes almost all of their energy, leaving hardly any time and resources to move upward. This brings tremendous frustration and consequently, many of them take the shelter of alcohol, drugs and gambling. This way they tend to forget the harsh realities of urban life.

[46] Raj Gandhi…75.
[47] Srinivas…133.
[48] Kopardekar,128.

Another visible impact of urbanization on migrants is seen in the breakdown of their family. Most rural migrants come from joint family structures, but the urban context forces them to become more nuclear, hence bringing a sense of alienation which adds to a sense of insecurity. Naturally, they tend to develop their caste, community networks to seek some sort of sense of belonging.

Towards Missional Reflections:

Looking at the huge presence of migrants in the Indian cities, some missional reflections are in order. Rather than providing insights for a missional response, I hope to raise pertinent questions that would provide a basis for missional action.

First of all, what does it mean for the urban church to take seriously the ministry among the migrants? To what extent do the migrants deserve the attention of the urban church? In what way does the urban church be informed, educated, equipped and mobilized to undertake effective ministry among these migrants? How can the urban church be made aware of the process and effects of changes that are taking place among migrants? In response to these questions, to what extent does the urban church need to be informed? Further, what kind of networking and partnership is to be developed between the likeminded churches and socio missional organizations? In what ways can the expertise and experience of mission societies be utilized by the urban church that is faced with the realities of migrants at their doorsteps?

Second set of questions pertains to the church's response to the needs of the migrants. What can be done to make the transition of the migrants smooth and productive in the cities of their choice? Should the church take the initiative in developing a network for providing assistance to them in securing jobs, providing temporary shelters, basic health and education for the children?

Thirdly, is there a way by which rural migrant's original solidarity with their kin, clan, caste, and ethnicity be enhanced by strengthening their family and kinship relationship in the city? In what way can this be done effectively and productively? What can be done to develop a similar network in other cities so as to learn from each other's experience?

Further, what will it take to witness to the migrant communities and plant churches among them? Since migrant cultures are holistic cultures, to what extent should we develop approaches that would take

into consideration holistic Christian witness among them? Is there a scope for urban missionaries to be placed among the rural migrants in cities? What would be some of the innovative and relevant ways of doing missions among such rural migrants? Related to this another crucial question with regard to planting of the kind of churches that would fit the context and needs of the rural migrants in the city? What kind of leadership structure is to be developed in these churches? And finally, what can be done to equip the rural migrants to share their new faith with their own community and people both in the city and back in their native villages?

This would require a lot of equipping and training for the urban church and her members so as to prepare them for the ministry among rural migrants. This equipping may be done both at the formal as well as non-formal levels. Equipping the church with appropriate strategies and approaches for ministering to the rural migrants is essential. If the city and particularly the migrants are perceived to be a mission field, then efforts are needed to make the whole church as a mission force. Equipping and mobilizing the urban church to minister effectively among various migrant groups is the need of the hour.